

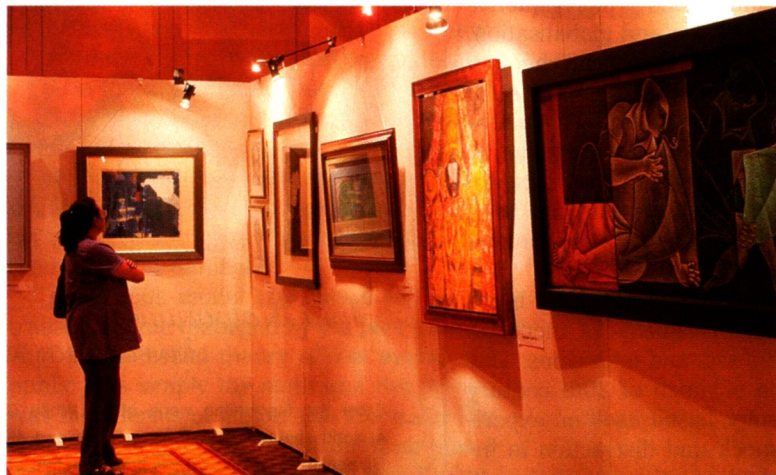


references to political and cultural events, scandal, globalisation, economy, and consumption. The media is seen as the truth/falsehood filter through which past and present are mobilised, a remarkable change from a few decades earlier where similar claims would not be voiced. The effects of the media are both denounced as well as sought after—by consumer groups, politicians, and public culture in general. For new globalising elites in India, the media, rather than politics or social movements, is the privileged site of civic discourse. The media becomes a source of news about its social effects: sting operations, piracy fears, and the loss of privacy, as increasing sections of the population become media producers.

bol, and minority cultural institutions began the wave, and demonstrated its power to all fundamentalist groups. Very few target the state, but prefer to reorganise the power constellation in the public realm to their favour, albeit temporarily.

The state's silence in these situations is part weakness and part deliberate distance. In the official order of globalisation, tolerance was for economic not cultural freedom. Cultural change was tolerated if it was restricted to high consumption, not for more transgressive acts. In general, globalisation was allowed for companies, for culture and education the Indira Gandhi model of control continues.

QAMAR SIBTAIN



A new generation: A woman looks at the work of young artists at a private gallery

Techno-culture remains the overarching cultural attractor of power in the public realm. Governments and corporations rush into biometric technologies as a magic wand for all problems: to catch truant workers and plugging welfare systems. A paranoid national ID card is already deployed in the border areas. The list is endless: CCTVs, brain-mapping, GIS, all hoping to render transparent a world that is more opaque by the day. Media theorist Paul Virilio once famously said the accident was the diagnostic of technology, to invent the plane was to equally invent the plane crash. In a world where everyday technology is no longer a monopoly of the state, the accident is a norm.

Hindutva was the first to understand a changed public realm. It moulded its politics into an effective machine for violent, guerrilla-like intervention: producing the perfect cultural technology for all acts of intolerance. Attacks by Vishwa Hindu Parishad and Shiv Sena activists on art exhibitions, global sym-

The new public realm after globalisation has been productive rather than paralysing. Access to media is more diverse than ever. The old cultural elites have lost stable control; a whole new generation of artists, filmmakers and writers crowd the landscape.

State censorship and cultural policing are rendered irrelevant as filmmakers and artists exploit non-linear networks, national and international. It is possible to access regional and international art-house cinema, a dizzying variety of music, partly through piracy and sharing. Blogs, e-mail lists, mobile phone photographs, text messages now transmit information that may not find a place in large media. An activist from Goa recently showed me a mobile phone photograph taken by local villagers exposing destructive mining in the state. The photograph first appeared in a blog, and eventually made it to the large Goan diaspora who wrote in massive letters of protest, and putting the company on the defensive. Activists of all types, who see themselves ignored in the fast moving big media interface, now constitute themselves as the media. The recent events in Singur demonstrate this. Condemned by liberal media commentators, Mamata Banerjee managed to orchestrate a social as well as media event, paralysing the state administration. The increase of negative references only increased the symbolic power of the protesters. Singur is not just the end of globalisation's party, it opens our eyes to an uncertain, exhilarating world where, for a moment, Some can become the Many.

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Intolerance Inc

IN THE OFFICIAL ORDER OF GLOBALISATION, ECONOMIC FREEDOM IS TOLERATED BUT NOT CULTURAL CHANGE. THERE, THE INDIRA GANDHI MODEL OF CONTROL CONTINUES.